

Player's Introduction to Avilund

A note from the designers;

Dear Traveler;

We are delighted to be providing you with a new setting in which you can explore, adventure, and experience the joy of discovery.

Discovery. That is the crux of this setting. Avilund is a place that none of you have been to before; it is a new setting in which you will find some things common to the traditional fantasy role-playing genre, but with our own interpretations and usages. You will also find a great deal that is new, and it is this discovery of the new that we hope you will most appreciate. There are new maps, religions, magic systems, monsters, equipment, monetary systems and rules. All of this has been designed to make you feel like a visitor to a new place, and to make you wish to discover more, and figure things out for yourselves.

I recall that my favourite moments in my role-playing career all revolved around the discovery of the new. Setting foot in Freeport was the first time that I realized this; after years of exploring the Realms, our group had become too intimate with the setting. Freeport was a welcome change because we didn't know what to expect. We didn't even know the price of longsword or where to buy a 10' pole. Going someplace new, and experiencing the unknown is what role-playing is all about.

The Avilund Player's Manual is largely composed of a collection of documents that are from the setting; there are journal entries from travelers in the setting, news paper clippings, text book selections, religious texts, and many other odds and ends. The collection does not provide a third-person, or omniscient view of Avilund; the selections have each been written by inhabitants of Avilund who are often biased and sometimes overtly partisan. A number of the key selections are correspondence and journals from travelers from distant lands who find themselves in the starting region of the campaign setting; they give an account from the view of an outsider, with all the wonder, bias and disgust that any traveler might record in a strange land. This is appropriate, because you, too, are an outsider just now.

While we want your first glimpse of Avilund to be through the eyes and narratives of the locals, we understand that some traditional-style descriptions must be provided (given in the 'synopsis', below). We won't provide the player with dozens of pages of dry and factual detail, vis-à-vis countless other gaming products, but will provide a brief framework. We hope that your understanding and experience in our setting is as biased and coloured as the locals, and indeed, as your opinions and views of the world you really live in; there is no factual manual for Earth, nor is there one for Avilund. Of the truth, Galileo wrote "All truths are easy to understand once they are discovered; the point is to discover them". Of the truth, Mark Twain also wrote "Truth is mighty and will prevail. There is nothing the matter with this, except that it ain't so."

Enjoy Avilund.

Les Blackwell

Synopsis

Avilund is old.

It is a continent which has been home to different races over scores of millennia, Men being the most recent masters of the continent. It is a large continent with several different climates and regions. There are balmy regions in the south of the continent where olive trees, orange groves and warm sea breezes prevail year round. In the far north, the snow never stops. In between is where the story begins for the characters; in the temperate region of Avilund known as the Republic of Waldheim. This is a fertile valley carved by two ancient rivers; the Wen and the Nith, in which men have prospered.

But men weren't the first to prosper there; the Elders, an enigmatic race that has been extinct for over 2000 years, once had a thriving society for millenia, and the city of Waldheim, located at the fork of the two great rivers, was the jewel of their civilization. They had great stone buildings, learning and magic on a scale that men have not been able to rival or match. However, they had a populous and determined enemy. The Ferrals, humanoid creatures of a thousand different forms and capabilities, fought with the Elders for millennia, and through attrition, managed to wipe them off the face of Avilund forever.

However, in the closing days of the Elders, Men came to Avilund. Their ships brought them from their island home across the sea to the east, to the warm shores of the South. There, the fertile lands of Avilund allowed Men to quickly grow and prosper. They built the Valdenwail, the first City of Men, over 3000 years ago, and from there expanded their civilization through much of the continent, and became involved in the war between the Elders and the Ferrals. Men chose to side with the Elders, but their help was too little too late. There was a brief coexistence of Men and Elders in Avilund, in which they exchanged some culture and learning for a short time, but this was cut short by the Ferrals, who conquered every Elder City, Waldheim last of all.

1750 years before the present, Men captured the City of Waldheim from the Ferrals, and have not surrendered it since. The civilization of Men has expanded and retracted over the centuries since this time, as they fought first with the Ferrals, and later among themselves. A great Empire of Men did grow out of the religion of the Men of the Valdenwail; their Cult of Saints provided the impetus and strength for the growth of this Empire.

The Cult of Saints, or the Saintly Faith, is the only openly accepted faith in the lands of the Old Empire, including the Republic. The basis of this religion is the aid that the Saints offer in the intermediary part of the afterlife, when the souls of the dead must travel through the Valley of Shadow to find their way to their destination; Heaven or Hell. Proper veneration of a given saint, or saints, in one's life is presumed to garner the aid of those saints in this perilous, post-death journey. Most souls are presumed to be trying to get to Heaven, which is a vaguely described paradise. However, some malignant souls are in search of Hell, and they too must ask for the help of their saints; the Black Saints, or Hellions. The peril of the journey is that demons, inhabitants of the Abyss, are constantly attacking the traveling soul, and attempting to drag the soul to the Abyss, where it will become another lost demon.

The first saint was Avitus. He was born on the Island, and spent his life in conflict with his brother, Gaul. The two brothers mutually destroyed each other in combat, and were the first two souls to make the journey through the Valley of Shadow; Avitus arriving in Heaven, and his brother in Hell. The story of the conflict between the brothers, and the descendants of Avitus is recorded in the ubiquitous copies of the *Tale of the Woodland King*. This book is something of a mix between a bible and an epic, and forms the basis for morality and social norms for the Men of Avilund.

The son (St. Severinius) and grandson (St. Sebald) of Avitus, and their contemporaries form what is known as the prime pantheon; a group of 11 saints (including Avitus) that are all men and women who were born in the Eastern Archipelago, and on the Island of Men. Though St. Avitus is nominally the head of the Saintly Faith, in reality, it is the Canon of St. Severinius that truly runs the church. In the Imperial South, the Canon of St. Avitus still has much power and authority, but beyond these lands, and in the Republic most of all, St. Avitus is not worshiped, and is regarded with some suspicion. This is because of the actions of the Scions.

The supreme head of the Saintly Faith is the Scion of Avitus; a direct descendant of Avitus himself. These men, who are only partly mortal (they seem to live uncommonly long lives, and are suspected to be bred with Earth-fallen angels), live within the ancient and empty halls of the Valdenwail, from where they rule the church, and formerly, an entire Empire. However, in the year 1348, the *Novae res Sanguinius*, the Bloody Revolution, shortened the reach of the Scion, the Emperor of Men. The Revolution started in the City of Waldheim (then called the City of Avitus), largely as a reaction to the *Repurgo Imperialis*.

The *Repurgo* was an anti-intellectual movement started by a sect of monks, and it became quite violent and bloody. For 200 years, the Empire was seized by terror, as roaming bands of these monks and their followers hunted down scholars, mages, historians, and countless other people they found suspect. Though this movement was not sanctioned or officially endorsed by the Scion, it was suspected that he did motivate and encourage it through his inquisitors. During this time, most of what had been recovered from the Elder cities had been destroyed, lost or hidden. Knowledge had plunged into the Dark Age.

However, this came to an end in 1348, with the Revolution. Organized resistance to the *Repurgo* was formed, and a group of masked lords in the City declared the City free of the Scion's will. From there, Revolution spread, and a great war was fought between two factions; the men of the traditional-minded South, and the men of the revolutionary north. In the end, the forces from the north, among them the army of the newly formed Republic of Waldheim, marched upon the Valdenwail. They were never able to breach the great Hedge of the Valdenwail, but a peace was signed, and the Scion relinquished control of the lands north of the Imperial Septum (a range of mountains that separates the two regions). It was at this point that the Empire fragmented into a dozen smaller countries, forming roughly the contemporary political boundaries.

While the countries south of the Imperial Septum have all remained theocracies, most in the north have evolved into republics and the like. In the very far north, feudal kingdoms are the norm.

Though the Scion and St. Avitus do not hold much sway in the Republic, the Saintly Faith is still largely present. Everyone who is concerned about their soul worships one or more saint, and the churches and shrines to these saints are everywhere. The Saintly Faith covers the realm of men entirely, but it is so largely regional in its practices and norms, that it is difficult to summarize it here. There are hundreds of saints, though only about 30-40 are commonly known by your average saintly citizen. There are shrines, churches and cathedrals to over 100 saints in the City, but there might be only one or two regionally-worshiped saints with buildings dedicated to them in some small villages.

The priests of the Saintly faith are able to perform 'miracles' (read 'cast cleric spells'). However, they do so much less often than those in the traditional fantasy genre, and their miracles are not typical of the lists found in other settings. Very few can cast 'cure light wounds'. Their miracle-lists are saint-specific, and all include saint-specific spells new to the DND game. Not all Saintly 'Priests' are able to perform miracles, and many people in the Avilund setting who do not wear the vestiments of the church can.

After the Revolution, an age of enlightenment followed, and continues to the present, during this start of this setting. Institutions of learning have again reached elite positions in society, after crawling out from hiding during the *Repurgo*. Academics all over the old Empire search feverishly for the documents and learning that was hidden or destroyed during the *Repurgo*, and for the sites of hidden Elder cities and knowledge. Lord's University, in Waldheim, is the largest and most esteemed university in the North, but there are dozens of smaller and capable institutions, most of which are strongly affiliated with St. Ignatius, the patron Saint of Learning.

The age of learning in which this setting begins is one that has produced competent doctors and surgeons, creative inventors, ambitious entrepreneurs, sophisticated legal systems, complicated economic inventions and systems (paper money, insurance, stock holding, etc), talented artists and musicians, and highly skilled statesmen and diplomats.

Magic is another issue, however. Before the *Repurgo*, Men employed some magic that they learned from the Elders, and discovered in the ruins of their abandoned cities. They were able to use this magic to help carve the Empire out of the dangerous wilderness that the Ferrals held against them. However, the Scion was ever distrustful of those who wielded this power, and inquisitions were launched in the past to ensure that practitioners of magic were harnessing this magic of the Elders, rather than the 'Black Faith', or power granted by demons, devils and hellions. These inquisitions concomitantly peaked with the *Repurgo*, and managed to do a lasting harm to the practice of magic, even in the more liberal regions of the old Empire such as Waldheim. The study and practice of magic is, strictly speaking, legal, but the general public is distrustful of mages and magic to this day. Magic remains a hidden art, and those few that are known to practice it are given a wide berth.

The enemies of Men in Waldheim are many. Any commoner would tell you that the 'Black Faith' is to blame for most of the ills of the Republic, from bad laws to bad harvests, high crime rates and infestations of rats. To be sure, there are covens of those who worship, and gain power from, the Black Saints, but the term 'Black Faith' is something of a catchall that would be used to describe such things as the Gypsies that live in the forest outside the City, those that harness the power of nature in the far-off wilderness, and semi-secret organizations that the elite of the City delight in forming. The true Black Faith is alive and well, though, and the characters are sure to cross paths with it.

The material world is often penetrated by angels, demons, devils, and a variety of other-worldly beings. Just as the term 'Black Faith' is oft-used by the ignorant public, the term 'demon' can be used to describe anything from a wayward beggar, a particularly clever and mischeivous rat, or a nasty storm cloud. Demons do exist in this world, though, and the characters are likewise likely to face one or more of them. They come in many forms and have many different abilities, strengths and weaknesses, that are, for the most part, largely unknown to the people of Avilund.

The Ferals remain a constant threat, after thousands of years of conflict. The populations of Ferals have ebbed and flowed over the centuries, following the military ambitions of the Empire. Today, they are assumed to be held at bay, hiding in the deepest forests, and the most remote mountain ranges of the old Empire. The term 'Feral' is also a catchall. This term includes any bipedal, roughly humanoid creature with any measure of intelligence. They are often malignant, sometimes misunderstood, and rarely scrupulous. They come in many shapes and sizes, colours, abilities, strengths and weaknesses. Terms like 'troll' or 'goblin' are common in the mythology of Avilund, but the characters won't be encountering any of these bromidic villains. The monsters of Avilund are all waiting to be seen for the first time, by the characters and players alike.